



News | Israel-Palestine conflict

As delegates walk out, Netanyahu tells UN Israel must ‘finish job’ in Gaza

The Israeli leader rails against his critics and denounces Western allies for recognising Palestine in fiery UN address.



 By **Tim Hume**

26 Sep 2025

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Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has delivered a defiant speech at the [United Nations General Assembly](#) (UNGA), attempting to justify his country’s genocide in Gaza and denouncing Western allies as global criticism over the nearly two-year war mounts.

Speaking at UNGA in New York on Friday, the increasingly isolated Israeli leader railed against the “disgraceful decision” by some Western countries in recent days to recognise a Palestinian state.

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“It will be a mark of shame on all of you,” he said.

“Your disgraceful decision will encourage terrorism against Jews, and against innocent people everywhere.”

Netanyahu, who is facing an International Criminal Court arrest warrant for alleged war crimes in Gaza, delivered his speech to a sparse audience because many delegates left the General Assembly hall in protest as he made his way towards the stage.

Thousands of people, meanwhile, took to the streets of New York to protest against Netanyahu’s presence in the city and denounce Israel’s war on the besieged Gaza Strip, where Israeli attacks have killed more than 65,000 people.

“He is not welcome to New York City,” a representative of the Palestinian Youth Movement told Al Jazeera at the demonstration.

“It is unconscionable that elected officials in the US and in New York City and nationally are rolling the red carpet for him”.



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During his speech, Netanyahu insisted that, despite the growing international pressure and condemnation of genocide, Israel “must finish the job” in Gaza following the Hamas-led attacks in October 2023, during which an estimated 1,139 people were killed.

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“Western leaders may have buckled under the pressure,” he said. “And I guarantee you one thing: Israel won’t.”

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Netanyahu’s speech was also broadcast into Gaza via loudspeakers, a fact he acknowledged in his speech, issuing a message directly to the Israeli captives held in the territory.

“We have not forgotten you, not even for a second,” he said. “The people of Israel are with you. We will not falter, and we will not rest until we bring all of you home.”

Netanyahu also claimed that his speech was being transmitted to the cellphones of people in Gaza, including Hamas leadership, and he issued an ultimatum that they should lay down their weapons and release the captives, or they would die.

Critics have said Netanyahu’s unwillingness to reach a ceasefire deal in Gaza has prevented the captives’ release, with many opponents, including members of the Israeli parliament, accusing the prime minister of prolonging the war for political purposes.



Throughout his speech, Netanyahu laid out a familiar narrative, repeatedly referring to the 2023 attack to justify continuing the war on Gaza.

He also detailed the “seven-front war” that Israel had since waged against its enemies in the region. Holding a map titled “The Curse” as a visual aide, he listed off the enemies Israel had dealt with around the region, including Gaza, Yemen, Iran, Syria, Lebanon and Iraqi militia.

Netanyahu was particularly scathing of Israel’s Western allies – but not the United States, which has been his country’s staunchest defender at the international organisation and main military backer.

“You know deep down that Israel is fighting your fight,” he told Western leaders. He also claimed, without evidence, that behind closed doors, leaders had thanked him for his country’s efforts in securing the world from “terror”.

Members of the US delegation in attendance could be seen applauding throughout the speech.

Netanyahu denied Israel was committing genocide in Gaza, as a [UN inquiry](#) and a growing number of experts have found, saying Israel’s military would not tell them to evacuate if they were trying to commit genocide.

He also denied Israel was deliberately starving the population of Gaza, where [famine](#) has been declared, blaming Hamas for stealing aid into the territory and selling it to finance the war.

In late June, an internal report by the US’s development agency, USAID, [concluded](#) that there was no evidence of the systematic looting of US-provided aid by Hamas.

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Israeli opposition leader Yair Lapid criticized Netanyahu’s UNGA address, calling it “a tired and whining” speech filled with “tired gimmicks.” He also highlighted how Netanyahu failed to present a peace plan to secure the release of Israeli captives being held in Gaza.

Gaza’s government was also critical of the speech and said on Friday that Netanyahu promoted “eight major lies” at UNGA in a bid to justify his war crimes and genocide in Gaza.

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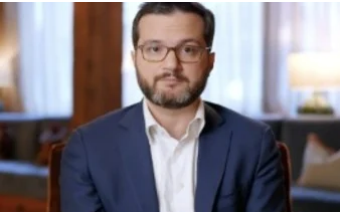
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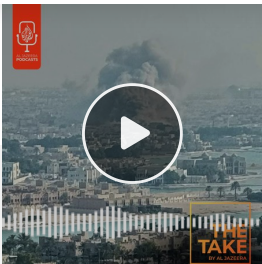
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